

The Silk Road

The trade route that allowed merchants to travel from east to west from Asia to Europe was known as the Silk Road. This road was first set up around 200 BCE and lasted until sea routes across the Indian Ocean replaced it in the 1500s CE. In addition to goods for trading, new ideas, religions, and inventions traveled along the Silk Road.

East to west

The Silk Road began in China. It stretched through the mountains and deserts of central Asia to the eastern Mediterranean Sea.



Horses were used to pull carts where the roads were good enough.

Horses and carts

Roman merchant ship

Transporting goods by sea was quicker and cheaper, but also more dangerous.

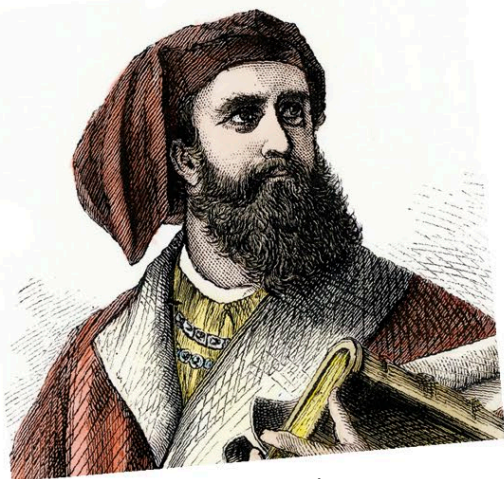
KEY (220 CE)



Main trade route

This was the path that most travelers and merchants followed on their journeys between east and west.

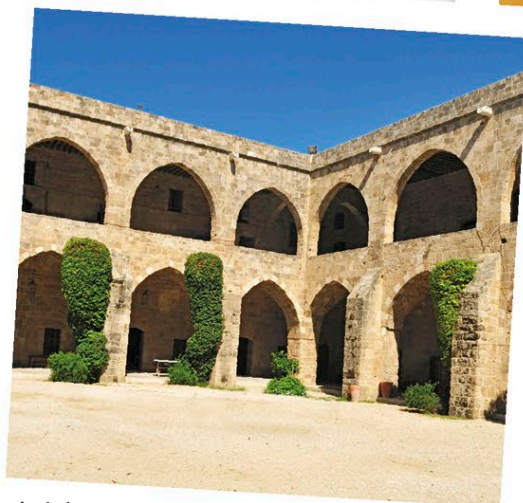
- | | |
|-----------------|-----------|
| Gold | Jade |
| Silver | Porcelain |
| Glassware | Paper |
| Cotton | Gunpowder |
| Grapes | Tea |
| Figs | Sugar |
| Walnuts | Spices |
| Ferghana horses | Silk |
| | Salt |



Marco Polo

Marco Polo

In 1271 the young Italian Marco Polo traveled along the Silk Road to China with his father and uncle, who were both merchants. He wrote a best-selling account of his travels when he returned home 24 years later.



A historic caravanserai in Lebanon

Caravanserais

Merchants traveling along the Silk Road stopped off in caravanserais, or inns. Here they could eat and sleep and let their animals rest.

West to east

Europe sent glassware, silver, gold, and cotton east to China. Horses from the Ferghana Valley in central Asia were much valued in China and traveled along the Silk Road to get there.



Roman glassware



Greek silver coin